transport and supply. The military strategy was based on the use of tumens as a useful building block causing reasonable shock and attack (Corvisier, 1994). The commander of a tumen was a tümen-ü noyan, a term sometimes translated ‘myriarch’, meaning commander of 10,000 (Hsiao, 1978).

9 The Kipchaks were a Turkic Nomad group. They thrived in the Middle Ages living in the parts of the Eurasian Steppe. The first mention of them is found in the eighth century as part of the Second Turkic Khaganate. It appears that they had settled in the Altai region from where they expanded elsewhere in centuries to come. Their first phase of expansion happened being the part of Kimek Khānate. The next phase of expansion was as a part of a confederation with the Cumans. They finally settled downin the Pontic–Caspian steppe, Syr Darya and Siberia. The Cuman–Kipchak confederation was conquered by the Mongols in the early thirteenth century.

10 The story behind etymology of their name is quite interesting. The Kipchaks interpreted their name as meaning ‘hollow tree’ (Middle Turkic: kuv ağaç) (Clauson, 1972). According to them, their original human ancestors gave birth to first progeny in inside a hollow tree (Baldick, 2012). Late Gyula Németh, was a Hungarian linguist and turkologist and a member of the Hungarian Academy of Sciences. He points the origin to be Siberian qıpčaq ‘angry, quick-tempered’. The same is attested only in the Siberian Sağay dialect (a dialect of Khakas language) (Golden, 1992). Klyashtorny links Kipchak to qovı, qovuq ‘unfortunate, unlucky’; yet Golden sees a better match in qıv ‘good fortune’ and adjectival suffix -čāq. Regardless, Golden notes that the ethnonym’s original form and etymology ‘remain a matter of contention and speculation’ (Golden, 1992).

Their name appears occasionally transliterated in other languages, such as Arabic: قفجاق, romanized: Qifjāq; Persian: قبچاق, romanized: Qabčāq/Qabcâq; Georgian: ყივჩაღები, romanized: Qivçaghebi; Turkish: Kıpçak; Crimean Tatar: Kıpçaq, Karachay-Balkar: Къыпчакъ, romanized: Qıpçaq; Uzbek: Qipchoq, Қипчоқ/قىپچاق; Uighur: قىپچاق, romanized: Qipchaq/Қипчақ; Kazakh: Қыпшақ, romanized: Qypşaq; Kumyk: Къыпчакъ, romanized: Qıpçaq; Kyrgyz: Кыпчак, romanized: Qıpçaq; Nogai: Кыпчак; Romanian: Copceac; and Chinese: ~ ~ ~ Qīnchá ~ Qīnchā ~ Kěfúchā ~ Kèbíshāo. Other English transliteration include Kypchaks and Qipchaks.

The Russian ‘Polovtsy’ was the name given to the Kipchaks and Cumans by the Rus’ people - hence the Polovtsian Dances at the end of act 2 of Alexander Borodin’s opera Prince Igor.

11 Youngest son of Timur, born in AD 1377.